The Black Clown and The Bitter River

By Langston Hughes

INTRODUCTION

The early blackface minstrel shows of the 19th century portrayed blacks as joyous, naive, superstitious, and ignorant—characteristics related to the way slaveholders in earlier years believed them to be. But in The Black Clown by Langston Hughes a black minstrel challenges this stereotype, discards his clown costume and asserts his basic humanity.

You laugh

Because I'm poor and black and funny—

Not the same as you—

Because my mind is dull

And dice instead of books will do

For me to play with

When the day is through.

I am the fool of the whole world.

4NG Fanatics

Laugh and push me down.

Only in song and laughter

I rise again—a black clown.

Strike up the music.

Let it be gay.

Only in joy

Can a clown have his day.

Three hundred years

In the cotton and the cane,

Plowing and reaping

With no gain—

Empty handed as I began.

A slave—under the whip,

Beaten and sore.

God! Give me laughter

That I can stand more.

God! Give me the spotted
Garments of a clown
So that the pain and the shame
Will not pull me down.

Freedom!
Abe Lincoln done set me free—
One little moment
To dance with glee.

Then sadness again—
No land, no house, no job,
No place to go.
Black—in a white world
Where cold winds blow.
The long struggle for life:
No schools, no work—
Not wanted here; not needed there—
Black—you can die.

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Nobody will care—

Yet clinging to the ladder,
Round by round,
Trying to climb up,
Forever pushed down.

Day after day
White spit in my face—
Worker and clown am I
For the "civilized" race.

Nigger! Nigger! Nigger!
Scorn crushing me down.
Laugh at me! Laugh at me!
Just a black clown!

Laugh at me then,
All the world round—

From Africa to Georgia

I'm only a clown!

But no! Not forever

Like this will I be:

Here are my hands

That can really make me free!

Suffer and struggle.

Work, pray, and fight.

Smash my way through

To Manhood's true right.

Say to all foemen:

You can't keep me down!

Tear off the garments

That make me a clown!

Rise from the bottom,

Out of the slime!

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Look at the stars yonder

Calling through time!

Cry to the world

That all might understand:

I was once a black clown

But now—

I'm a man!

TRANSITION

A large portion of the white population, however, had difficulty accepting the basic humanity of the black man. Instead radical steps were taken to keep the black man "in his place. For many African Americans growing up in the South in the 19th and 20th centuries, the threat of lynching was commonplace. The popular image of an angry white mob stringing a black man up to a tree is only half the story. Lynching, an act of terror meant to spread fear among blacks, served the broad social purpose of maintaining white supremacy in the economic, social and political spheres. The Bitter River is dedicated to the memory of Charlie Lang and Ernest Green, each fourteen years old when lynched together beneath the Shubuta Bridge over the Chicasawhay River in Mississippi, October 12th, 1942.
The Bitter River by Langston Hughes

There is a bitter river
Flowing through the South.
Too long has the taste of its water Been in my mouth.
There is a bitter river Dark with filth and mud.
Too long has its evil poison
Poisoned my blood.

I've drunk of the bitter river
And its gall coats the red of my tongue,
Mixed with the blood of the lynched boys
From its iron bridge hung,
Mixed with the hopes that are drowned there
In the snake-like hiss of its stream
Where I drank of the bitter river
That strangled my dream:
The book studied-but useless,
Tool handled-but unused,
Knowledge acquired but thrown away,
Ambition battered and bruised.
Oh, water of the bitter river

4NG Fanatics

With your taste of blood and clay,
You reflect no stars by night,
No sun by day.

The bitter river reflects no stars-
It gives back only the glint of steel bars
And dark bitter faces behind steel bars:
The Scottsboro boys behind steel bars,
Lewis Jones behind steel bars,
The voteless share-cropper behind steel bars,
The labor leader behind steel bars,
The soldier thrown from a Jim Crow bus behind steel bars,
The 150 mugger behind steel bars,
The girl who sells her body behind steel bars,
And my grandfather's back with its ladder of scars
Long ago, long ago-the whip and steel bars -
The bitter river reflects no stars.

"Wait, be patient," you say.
"Your folks will have a better day."
But the swirl of the bitter river

Takes your words away.
"Work, education, patience
Will bring a better day-"
The swirl of the bitter river
Carries your "patience" away.
"Disrupter! Agitator!
Trouble maker!"you say.

The swirl of the bitter river
Sweeps your lies away.
I did not ask for this river
Nor the taste of its bitter brew.
I was given its water
As a gift from you.
Yours has been the power
To force my back to the wall
And make me drink of the bitter cup
Mixed with blood and gall.

You have lynched my comrades
Where the iron bridge crosses the stream,
Underpaid me for my labor,

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And spit in the face of my dream.
You forced me to the bitter river
With the hiss of its snake-like song-
Now your words no longer have meaning-
I have drunk at the river too long:
Dreamer of dreams to be broken,
Builder of hopes to be smashed,
Loser from an empty pocket
Of my meagre cash,
Bitter bearer of burdens
And singer of weary song,
I've drunk at the bitter river
With its filth and its mud too long.
Tired now of the bitter river,
Tired now of the pat on the back,
Tired now of the steel bars
Because my face is black,
I'm tired of segregation,
Tired of filth and mud,
I've drunk of the bitter river
And it's turned to steel in my blood.

4NG Fanatics

Oh, tragic bitter river

Where the lynched boys hung,

The gall of your bitter water

Coats my tongue.

The blood of your bitter water

For me gives back no stars.

I'm tired of the bitter river!

Tired of the bars!

SOURCE INFORMATION

FOR BOTH POEMS

Author: Langston Hughes
Book: The Collected Poems of Langston Hughes
ISBN: 978-0679764083
Publisher: Vintage Contemporaries
Date(Month/Year): Oct 1995

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier

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